



# Sex in Space

Humans love the idea of space exploration. They also love copulation. But are the two compatible?

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**M**ankind has always been fascinated with travelling through space. A possible reason for doing so, apart from exploration and scientific discovery, is also human survival, in the event that something were to happen to Earth and we needed to move elsewhere. The biggest problem with space travel is that everything is just so darn far away, and thus it takes forever to get there. Unless we get warp drives to travel faster than light, any interstellar travel attempted by humans will involve long periods of time spent in a spacecraft. Even a mission to nearby Mars would involve a journey of at least 1.5 years one-way. Now a normal human is bound to get a little amorous...

## Has anyone done it yet?

Of course that's the first question you're bound to ask! With so many shuttle missions, building and maintaining two space stations, mixed-gender crews... how could you not ask? Sadly, even in space, sex is taboo enough to be kept a secret.

The only married couple to ever travel to space together was Jan Davis and Mark Lee, but they're not telling.

In all fairness, being an astronaut involves a very, very busy schedule. With the time they can spend in space very limited, their entire day is planned out in great detail, every move is monitored



and, at such close quarters, privacy is hard to find. The only privacy would be in the sleeping pods, but that too is a shared environment.

It's interesting to note that no space agency specifically forbids physical intimacy, but being chosen from amongst 7 billion people to go to space and then not being able to keep it in your pants seems like it would get you more than a fair share of ragging amongst your peers... if not expulsion from the space program. Given all of the above, it's more than likely that humans haven't got off in space, yet.

The Russian space agency did consider sending their cosmonauts inflatable sex dolls, but decided against doing so, as they would then have had to work that particular activity into the cosmonauts' already tight schedules... At least we know that people have thought about this before, and we're not perverts for asking the question.

## Docking challenges

Physical intimacy in space is beset by both psychological and physiological problems. First, any discussion of space sex is moot

if neither your partner nor you are in the mood. You are living in a tiny, smelly, hot, claustrophobic, man-made structure with little or no privacy, minimalistic facilities, for years on end after all. So like us, the average Mumbai native? Trust us, it's no fun, but yet humanity finds a way here...

Considering that the average Mumbai-kar isn't travelling to Mars, first-worlder astronauts might instead hate the darkness, loneliness and silence and want to hang themselves instead – but that's another article, given the lack of gravity.

Assuming that some people will still get in the mood, you have to remember that unlike on Earth, coitus in space has serious challenges. Biology dictates that the lack of gravity causes blood redistribution problems – fluid shifting to the upper part of the body and reduced blood flow – so that makes space erections a problem. As if it wasn't hard enough already!

But mankind finds a way. To quote cosmonaut Aleksandr Laveykin, when asked about sexual activity by Mary Roach in her book 'Packing for Mars', "My friends ask me 'how are you making sex in space?' I say 'by hand.'"

So let's proceed assuming that mankind, or just man in this case, finds a way to do his bit, the zero gravity environment of space means that more effort is required to do anything. Newton's third law of energy tells us that any slight movement will cause an equal and opposite reaction in another body. Put simply, thrust once against someone, and they fly away from you. It would be tough for people to maintain prolonged physical contact while floating about in space. Considering the trouble that would be involved in just a kiss, we think you can safely forget finding the Zero G spot.

Still, we shall not be overcome! When all else fails, a little bondage is called for. We could strap ourselves down to our beds, right? Sure, but not with the current beds being used on the International Space Station (ISS) or the shuttles. These are made to be physically constraining for one person, and thus are almost impossible to fit two – unless we get an inventive new space Kamasutra.

An alternate solution would be the 2suit – a flight suit with good old Velcro